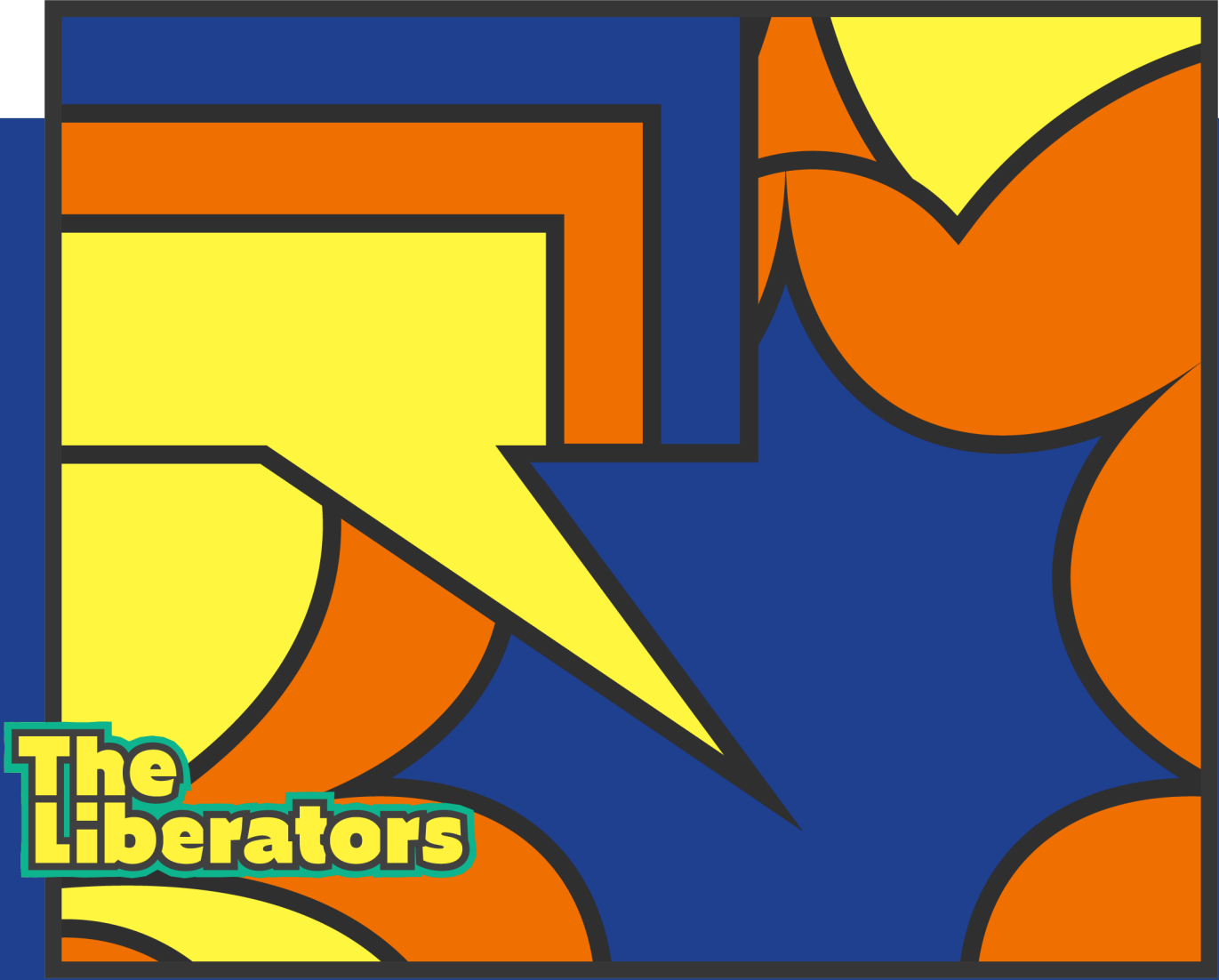


Refine Tough Or Unclear Product Backlog Items With Stakeholders

A do-it-yourself workshop to refine tough or unclear items with Liberating Structures (e.g. UX Fishbowl and 1-2-4-ALL)



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

Sometimes, you run into Product Backlog items that are both huge *and* very hard to break-down into smaller bits that are still valuable in their own right. Other times, some items are very large *and* very unclear.

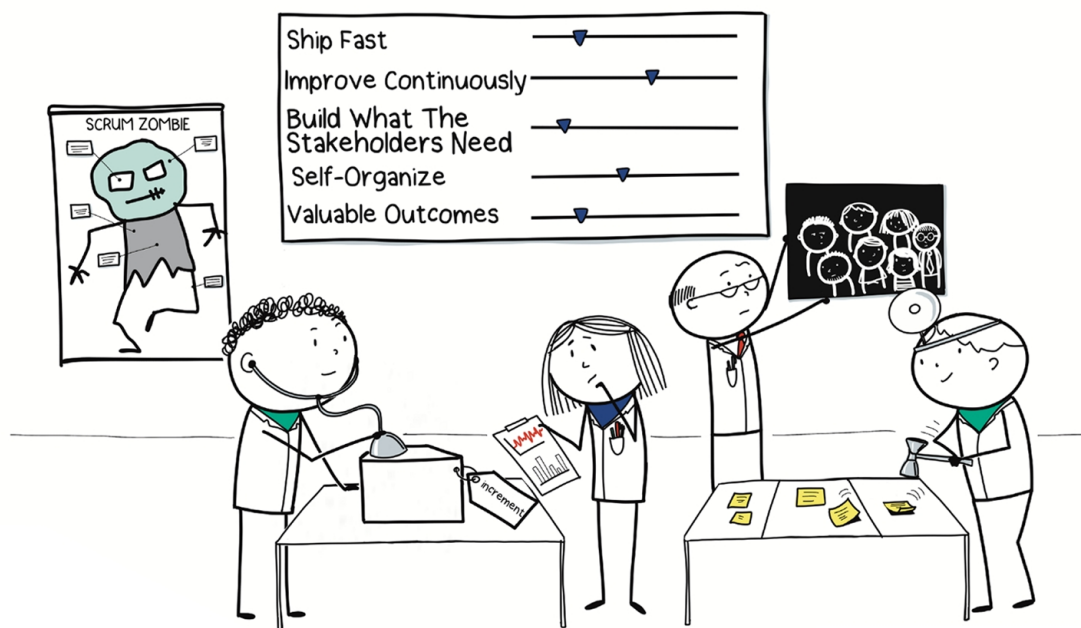
In our work, we've consistently found that stakeholders – especially users – hold the key to refinement. When they have the opportunity to tell the story of how they would use a certain item, or what it means to them, everything tends to come into focus.

So we designed this string of Liberating Structures to leverage the perspective of your stakeholders. By bringing them in, you will find novel and creative ways to break-down and refine those tough and unclear items. Even better; it builds bonds between your Scrum team and its stakeholders, and makes the purpose of your product clear.

Give this string a try, and let us know the results!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Scharlau & Barry Overeem
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Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Get Everyone's Thinking Started With "Impromptu Networking"

  20 min

Step 3: Explore Items with UX Fishbowl

  30 min

Step 4: Break-down Items With 1-2-4-ALL

  20 min

Step 5: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

  15 min

Step 5: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 90 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



The structures we use here should do all the work. All you need to do is invite the right people.

Impact On Survival



Once stakeholders get involved in refinement, it becomes progressively easier to build the right things.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 8 participants and onward. You can also run parallel sessions of this string at the same time, involving many more Scrum Teams and many more stakeholders.

Intended Audience

This workshop is designed for one Scrum Team and its stakeholders. For best effect, invite between 3 and 6 stakeholders that actually use, or will be using, your product on a regular basis.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- With your Product Owner, identify one large item on the Product Backlog that you want to break-down and would benefit from the perspective of stakeholders.
- Invite 3–6 stakeholders that might have a good perspective on this item. The most useful input always comes from (potential) users who will be using this item on a regular basis, so prioritize them above other stakeholders.
- Optionally, you can print [the cheatsheet in this post](#) to offer some help when everyone is exploring ways to break-down the work.



The Purpose Of Product Backlog Refinement

Product Backlog Refinement exists, first and foremost, to break down large chunks of work into smaller chunks of work. As with everything in the Scrum framework, this makes it easier to work empirically. If we would work on large items – that take weeks or even months to complete end-to-end – we would be unable to get frequent feedback from our actual stakeholders. This introduces the significant risk that we make incorrect assumptions about what stakeholders need that, once falsified, require us to go back and change everything.

So instead our aim with Scrum is to more frequently deliver smaller chunks of work so that our stakeholders can give us meaningful feedback that spurs new ideas, changes to what has already been done, or uncovers bugs that need to be addressed. In short, delivering small bits of work is a great way to help us think and understand what is needed.

All the work on your Product Backlog should eventually be refined to make it small enough – but only when you're about to start work on it in a coming Sprint. When something is "small enough" depends very much on your context. But as a starting point, your team should refine to a degree where they can comfortably select and complete multiple items in a single Sprint. Experienced Scrum teams will tell you that smaller is generally even better.

Resources

- Blog post: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk and Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Scrum Mythbusters: Refinement is a required meeting for the entire Scrum](#)

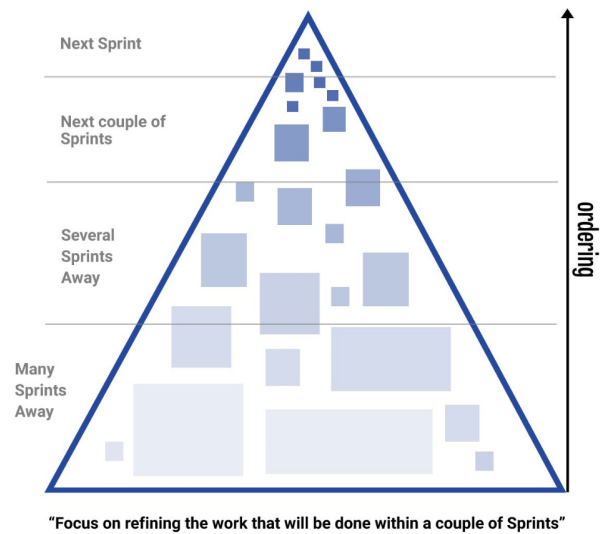


Image by Christiaan Verwijs (theliberators.com)

Vertical Slicing, And The Role Of Stakeholders



Horizontal Slicing

The act of breaking down items on your Product Backlog is often called "slicing" or "decomposition". Roughly speaking, there are two ways to slice items. In the first case, items are sliced horizontally; along technological boundaries. For example, an item like "A customer can order a product in the webshop" is broken down into "Set up a database for orders", "Create front-end for webshop" and "Build payment gateway". This form of slicing comes naturally to many developers. And while it does result in smaller items, none of them are valuable to stakeholders on their own. Inspection by stakeholders is also only useful when all the small items have been completed, which makes it hard to work empirically if the items are spread out over multiple Sprints. In virtually all cases, horizontal slicing is sub-optimal.

Vertical Slicing

Another approach is vertical slicing. Here, items are sliced vertically along functional boundaries. The goal is to end with a set of smaller items that can still be inspected by stakeholders individually, and maybe even released already. For example, an item like "A customer can order a product in the webshop" can be broken down into "A customer can order a single product through a form", "A customer can pay for their order with credit card", "A customer receives an invoice for the order". For each item, it is likely that multiple technological layers will be changed (e.g. database, front-end, logic).

Unfortunately, vertical slicing is often harder and requires more creativity. It also requires that teams clearly understand the functional needs, as they offer the best avenues for slicing. This is where the involvement of stakeholders – and especially users – is so important. They can help you clarify their needs by telling you what they expect. Furthermore, they can help your team discover what needs should be fulfilled first, and which needs can be fulfilled later (or through alternate means).

This string offers one way to involve your stakeholders in refinement. While it makes it easier to refine items, it also builds bonds between the Scrum team and its stakeholders. And it is a great way for developers to train their skills to slice work functionally, and vertically, instead of horizontally.

Resources

- Blog post: [10 Powerful Strategies For Breaking Down Work in Scrum](#)



Step 1: Opening

Open the gathering. We always find it best to do this quickly and get into the interaction as soon as possible.

Steps

1. **2 min** Invite the Product Owner to briefly explain the item that you selected for this session. This is also a good opportunity to introduce the stakeholders.
2. **1 min** Give a very quick overview of what's to come. But jump into the next step as soon as you can to keep the energy high.



Step 2: Get Everyone's Thinking Started With "Impromptu Networking"

Once the item is introduced, the next step is to get some initial thoughts and questions on the table. This will provide helpful input for the next steps.

Invitation

"What thoughts come to mind for you about this item? What potential do you see? What makes it difficult?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Ask everyone to individually and silently reflect on the invitation.
2. **3 min** Form pairs and have them share what they wrote down. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms. Encourage members of the team to pair with stakeholders, and not with another member of the team.
3. **6 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations. People may start noticing patterns in their responses.
4. **4 min** Ask the group to briefly share the patterns that seem most important to today. Which thought and observations appeared the most?

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Rapidly share novel ideas and make personal connections with 'Impromptu Networking'](#)





Step 3: Explore Items with UX Fishbowl



Now that you've selected one or more tough items for further analysis, the next step is to explore what they would look like from the perspective of stakeholders. The stories that stakeholders tell often open avenues for breaking down large and tough items into smaller items that are still useful to them. The Liberating Structure [User Experience Fishbowl](#) is a great way to tell these stories and to listen to them.

Invitation

"Imagine for a moment that this item on the Product Backlog is already part of the product. Tell the story of how, when, and why you would use it. What steps are involved? What makes it useful for you? What might put you off?"

Steps

1. If you do this in-person, create an inner circle of chairs (3 to 7). Ask relevant stakeholders to take a seat in the inner circle (the fishbowl). Everyone else positions their seats in close concentric circles around the inner circle. If you do this virtually, the inner circle turns on microphones and webcams and everyone else turns theirs off.
2. **10 min** State the invitation of the UX Fishbowl and invite the inner circle to start an informal conversation about it, as if they're in a car together or at a coffee shop. The outer circles listen and observe with full attention, take notes and remain silent throughout.
3. **5 min** Invite everyone in the outer circles to form small groups (2–3 people) and use their notes to identify big questions that, when answered, might inspire ideas for how to refine this item into smaller items. For example, which parts should be done first, what can be done later? What can be solved by existing means, even when it is not ideal? Collect the questions so that the stakeholders can use them as input for the next round. If you do this step virtually, you can form break-out rooms for the small groups.
4. **10 min** Invite the inner circle to answer the submitted questions in whatever order works for them. The outer circles listen and take notes, and turn off their webcam and microphone when done virtually. Continue until all questions have been answered, or until the timebox expires.

Our Findings

- Sometimes, the inner circle can take their conversation into an abstract domain, talking about things that have little bearing on the item under discussion. If that happens, gently remind them to bring the conversation back to the item and how they would use it in the real world. What would the timeline look like for this item? What step would stakeholders take first? What would happen then? What do they expect will happen?

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- The [article](#) we wrote about User Experience Fishbowl
- Blog post: [Building Understanding Between Scrum Teams and Management with Liberating Structures](#)

Step 4: Break-down Items With 1-2-4-ALL



With the stories of the stakeholders in mind, the next step is to invite everyone present to discover how these stories inform the potential break-down and refinement of items on the Product Backlog.

Invitation

"Based on what you've heard from the stakeholders, what opportunities or creative solutions do you see for breaking up this large item into smaller ones that are still valuable in their own right?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask everyone – stakeholders and team members alike – to first individually and in silence reflect on the invitation and the stories they heard.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3. **4 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4. **8 min** Together, identify the most powerful and creative strategies that you identified as a group. Capture what the break-down looks like on the Product Backlog.

Our Findings

- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate many ideas, the group as a whole usually will.
- If the group is unable to identify any useful strategies, this is a good opportunity to reflect on what makes this so hard. What skills or techniques are missing that might simplify this? Why are they not present? You can always try another round of 1-2-4-ALL to dig deeper.

Resources

- Blog post: [10 Powerful Strategies To Break Down Product Backlog Items in Scrum \(with cheatsheet\)](#)
- Our [Powerful Questions deck](#), among other questions, contains 10 powerful questions to facilitate in breaking down items.



Step 5: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

Now that you've broken down the item into smaller parts, what else remains? The Liberating Structures [15% Solutions](#) is very useful for this.

Steps

1. **2 min** Invite everyone to identify one or two personal next steps. How can they personally contribute to the successful break-down and implementation of this item? What else makes sense, and is something that they have the autonomy and resources to contribute to?
2. **5 min** Invite people for form pairs to share their 15% Solutions, preferably mixing team members and stakeholders. If you're doing this virtually, use breakout rooms. Optionally, you can ask everyone to write down their 15% Solutions on a shared workspace.
3. **8 min** Debrief with the entire group and give people the opportunity to share their 15% Solutions.

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?"

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

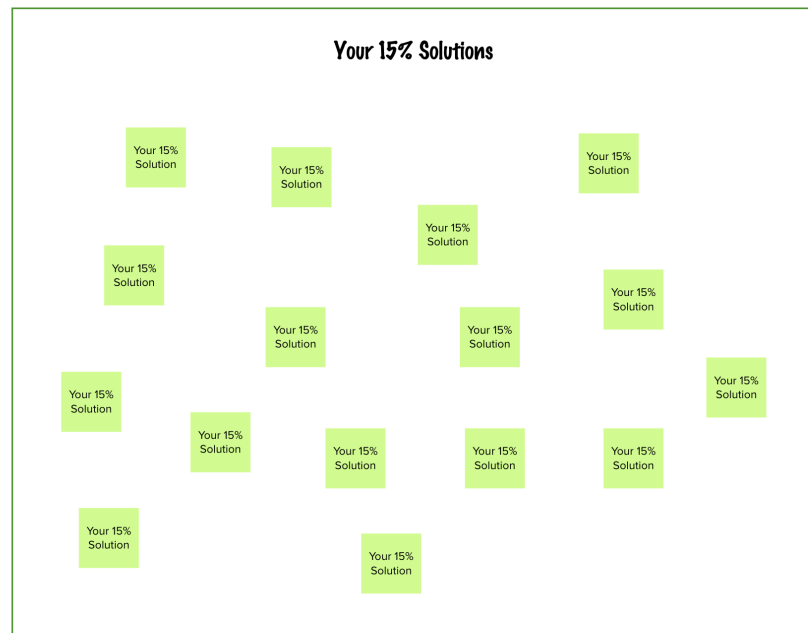
Step 1

Position yourself in the scenario you recognize the most and write down a personal next step.

What is an improvement that you can make, without needing approval from someone else or resources you don't have access to?

Step 2

Pair up and share your 15% Solution while giving and getting help to refine your next step



Step 5: Closing

If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this gathering?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

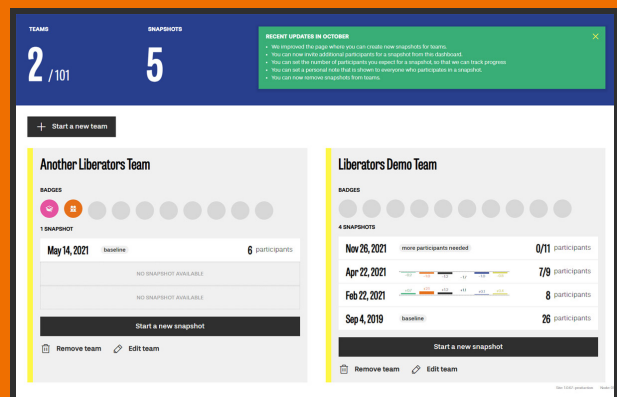
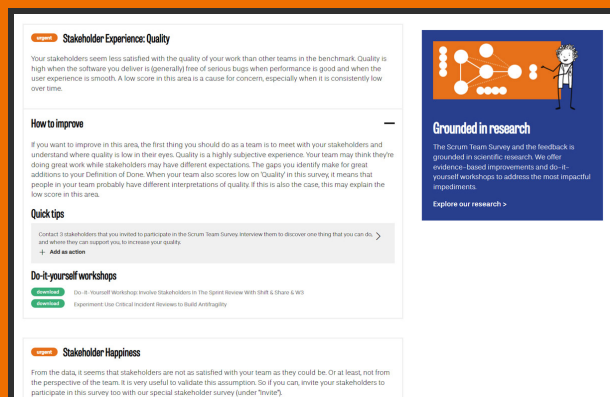
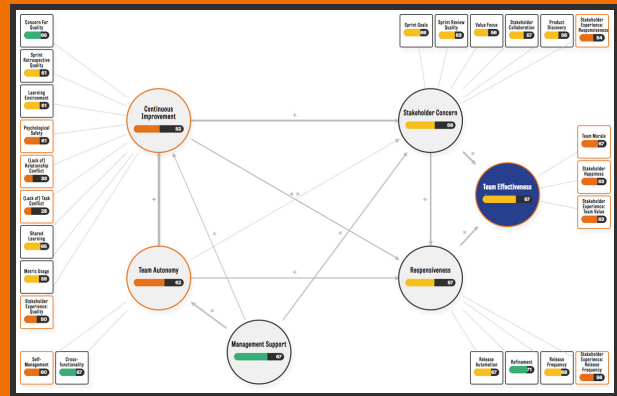
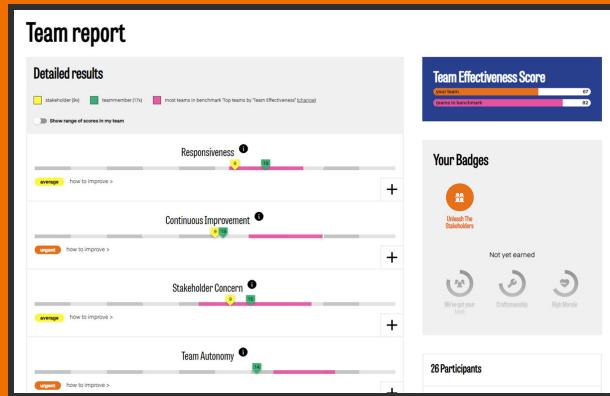
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



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	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
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Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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